



Chris Maggio

Culture

Dirtbags Made Comedian Stavros Halkias Famous. Now He's Helping Them Remake Their Lives.

The podcaster and self-described former incel never gave up on himself, and he coaches his listeners to do the same.

By Jack Crosbie, Photography by Chris Maggio

September 10, 2025



SAVE THIS STORY

This interview is part of the State of the American Male in 2025, a special report on masculinity. Read more about the issue from GQ editor-in-chief Will Welch [here](#) and read the results of GQ's 2025 State of Masculinity survey [here](#).

Stavros Halkias shows up at a Greek restaurant in Astoria, Queens with a massive suitcase in tow. I ask him if he's headed straight to the airport. No, he says—he's headed to the photoshoot for this story. "When you're a bigger guy, turns out they make you bring your own clothes," he says. What he doesn't say is that we both know he's going to end up taking them off anyway.





Essential style, wellness, and shopping advice in your inbox

Enter your email

SIGN UP

By signing up, you agree to our [user agreement](#) (including [class action waiver and arbitration provisions](#)), and acknowledge our [privacy policy](#).

That's Halkias: comfortable in his own skin. Assured in his masculinity. Playing to type—the funny fat guy—but subverting it at every opportunity by being the sexiest, horniest, and somehow most respectful pervert at the comedy show. Halkias got famous as one third of *Cum Town*, a comedy podcast that mashed anti-PC shock humor with surprisingly egalitarian politics, giving a generation of disaffected, economically depressed young men a constant stream of shit-talk tempered with leftist motifs. For years, men ate it up, so much so that hosts Halkias, Adam Friedland, and Nick Mullen shot to individual stardom.

“It's insane how good my life has gotten,” Halkias tells me at one point, seeming shocked. After the podcast ended in 2022, he wrote and starred in 2024's *Let's Start a Cult* and booked a starring role in the Shane Gillis-helmed Netflix series *Tires*. He followed that up with a role in Yorgos Lanthimos's upcoming *Bugonia*, and, a few days after we talked, was announced in a supporting role for A24's in-production film about the life of a young Anthony Bourdain.





But we don't get to that right away. We spend the first 20 minutes of the interview trading Greek bona-fides. I have none, but my wife is Greek-American, and Halkias, who

was raised by Greek immigrants in Baltimore, knows all about her Florida hometown due to its famous all-Greek sponge docks. A woman walking down the street past our sidewalk table looks at us as though she's just seen, say, Harry Styles: a double take, huge smile, tentative approach to say hello.

"My fiance's a huge fan of you," she says. "We're literally getting married Sunday."

"Ok COOL," Stavvy says, grinning.

"He's going to freak out, can we take a picture?"

That's life, nowadays, for Halkias, the uncle-king of Astoria. While becoming more recognizable, he's no less approachable, thanks in part to his funny and intimate solo podcast, *Stavvy's World*. Produced by his childhood friend Eldis Sula, it includes a call-in portion in which Halkias offers advice about how his listeners can, in his words, not be incels—some of which he shared with *GQ*.

What does being a man mean to you?

I mean, being a man in particular, I don't think about it that much. I think that's one of the advantages of being a white guy. You're the default in society, unfortunately. You don't ever consider your identity because everything is shaped towards your identity from the time you're younger. I think that's also why people are mad about some of that being under scrutiny.

There's definitely elements of being a man that I think are cool. I still like hanging with the fellas. I do love the team atmosphere. I grew up playing sports. I had nothing but brothers. My dad was a contractor. I spent summers going to work with him, going to Greek coffee shops, where it's just a bunch of dudes riling each other up, just gambling illegally, looking at pornography together. You know what I mean? That shit is fun to me.

It seems that, anecdotally at least, the version of masculinity that's popular today has become almost more traditional than it was five years ago.

Getting jacked is cool. I'm trying to get jacked. I will probably be one of those guys on steroids in his fifties. That shit's fucking awesome. Being a provider, in theory, that's fucking cool. A thing that I'm really proud of is that I grew up poor. I've been successful. I'm proud that I can take care of my family. These traditional things, they're not bad. What's bad is making it a zero-sum game. In my head, I don't see them as being at odds, masculinity and progress. You're not stripping anything from men by asking them to just use some of that—if we want to say there's some advantages to masculinity—using some of those advantages to help other people.

Do you personally feel pressure in certain situations to act more traditionally masculine?

No, not at all. Why does this have to be performative? The rhetoric around this is bizarre, because a lot of guys pretend we're going to go back to a hunter-gatherer lifestyle. You don't have to be that masculine if you don't want to be fucking masculine. I do, like I said, like the camaraderie of it, I like taking care of my family. I have that competitiveness, or that want to do the best that I can. I don't know if we want to attribute that to masculinity, but certainly, in some ways, I am. In other ways, I'm not. I'm soft as hell, I try to be more in touch with emotions, I try to leave some of the negative aspects of it, like anger issues, violence, all that shit. I think that's what everybody should shoot for. Be whatever amount of masculine you want to be in whatever direction you want to be.

What makes you comfortable in that version of masculinity?

I definitely have a glaring difference from the traditional ideal of a masculine man is—I've been fat my whole life. I received the scorn of traditional masculinity. I definitely felt that growing up. I'm pretty lucky that the funny fat guy is an archetype. Every crew of bullies has a fat wisecracking guy that's there. I played football, I was athletic, whatever. But that was also me trying to fit in in a way that sometimes probably wasn't that good for me.

I was in school plays my whole life, and then something shifted in seventh grade. I just remember that being a time where you're the most susceptible to some of these shitty

ideas. I remember getting offered a part in, it was probably *You're a Good Man, Charlie Brown*, or something. But I didn't get the titular Charlie, I got offered some other part. I was like, "Theater is fucking gay, dude." I was like, "Our theater teacher's fucking gay, dude. I don't want to be around that guy."

It was fucked up. It was pure sour grapes, the fact that I wanted to be fucking Charlie Brown, and then I was like, "I'm 13, it's time to get strong, it's time to be a football player."

I certainly would've been better off in the long run for my life if I had stuck with theater. I would still have played sports, don't get me wrong, but I should have just admitted I wasn't good enough to get the part and I should have worked harder. Balanced my life out that way instead of pretending like, "This shit's not for me," when I got my feelings hurt and lashing out in a very traditionally negative way.

That is such a universal experience of being a man, being confronted with inadequacy for one of the first times in a major way. And the information environment that kids are in now...

I think about myself when I was 14, 15, and I would've been really susceptible to a lot of this stuff. I was a loser. I was nervous to talk to girls, I didn't feel comfortable in my body, I was getting attacked for being fat. Luckily, I was good at making fun of people, but if there was some ripped dude who's good at beating people up that was like, "I know how to get pussy. All you have to do is control women and treat them poorly..." If they shot me with the Andrew Tate ray when I was 14, shit might've been bad for me.

All we had was Dane Cook CDs.

There was "I Hope They Serve Beer In Hell," Tucker Max. There's always been some of that.

Tucker Max! That's who it was.

If I'm trying to do anything with the call-in show, I'm trying to de-radicalize incels, because I was an incel. I actually can tell you how to change your life, and it's not to necessarily blame others. There's this weird blaming of women for how much of a loser you are, right? Yeah, life is uncomfortable and there's going to be moments where you have to be brave, but the end goal isn't do steroids and chain a woman to the oven, so she can cook you a grass-fed bison all fucking day and just have bone marrow.

So what are the most important things that we need to teach young men in these formative years?

I guess the lessons are twofold. First of all, you're not a piece of shit for laughing at fucked-up stuff. These things are funny. We're not going to pretend they're not funny, but understand they're just jokes and it shouldn't be the way you treat other people in society.

And, then, become the best version of yourself. For me, that's really the biggest lesson, right? It sounds so fucking boring to just say, "Be yourself," but guess what? Some of you

aren't going to get fucking jacked, some of you aren't going to be crypto fucking billionaires.

The way out of being an incel is understanding you can be a fucking loser, you don't have to be *the* exact ideal. Be the ideal version of you. Even at your worst, there's more people in the world that want to fuck you than you'll ever be able to fuck. Truly, they're out there. You just have to find them. The quickest way out of being an incel, being a nice, good hang, that cares about other people, is empathetic. I promise you, in the long run, you will have better results that way by being yourself and being nice and putting yourself out there.

The time I had the most success with women, I was 5'7", 350 pounds. You know what I mean? I was in horrible shape, but I did believe in myself, and now I'm trying to get that together. It's about constant growth and it's about always improving yourself, but that's the way out of being an incel. You do have to hold yourself accountable, but don't blame other people. Don't complain if you're not trying to find a solution. I think that's literally an Arnold Schwarzenegger thing.

I think that's the lesson I would give to them, because if I can do it, brother, you can do it too. I was 22, I had hooked up with one girl. I was fat, bald, broke, living at home with my parents, and I turned it all around. You can turn it around, too.

Who taught you that? Who taught you how to be a man?

I said it, but fucking Arnold Schwarzenegger. Action movies, sports movies. You know what I mean? As corny as it is, sports were big for me. *Rocky*, the underdog story. Obviously, my father, I had male role models or whatever, but I think sometimes our dads can give these incomplete versions of what it means to be a guy, and maybe sometimes you can learn off their mistakes.

My mom supported us in so many ways. She was really the rock that our family was built on. My mom pumped me up a lot. She probably overdid it. My mom thought I was going to be one of those kids that was going to graduate from Harvard at 12. But the mix of the tough love from my dad and the support from my mom helped me become this guy where you're not really satisfied, but you also believe in yourself.

You mentioned getting your fitness together. How have your ideas of wellness changed in the last five years?

Early on in my career it was like, "Oh, this is fun. Let me get as fucked up as possible. Let me get good at something so I get attention from women, and let me get drunk, fuck any girl that will let me, and eat like shit to reward myself." There's also a little bit of nihilism, living like nothing really matters. You're on the path to a coward's suicide where it's like, "I don't want to take care of myself. Who cares? I'm not going to be around forever." And then my life's gone pretty good. I got a nephew, my best friends have had kids, and I'm like, "Oh, I've gotten successful. There's people I care about. I guess I want to live."

So I've been trying over these last five years to lose a little weight. I did really well during the pandemic, and then I started working, got fat as fuck again. I just want to do whatever it takes to stick around, with the ultimate goal of being... I never want to get skinny, but I want to be strong. On the road, especially on tour, I just started walking. I liked to call myself the 20,000-step bastard. Every day on the road, I'd walk like eight miles. I would walk until my feet hurt, and then over time my feet stopped hurting, I could walk.

The thing that's helped me is be completely honest with yourself, and slowly build from there. I started doing some easy body weight exercise—Arnold Schwarzenegger has an app called the Pump—I started at the very bottom. For the rest of my life, I want to get to a point that's sustainable. And then get jacked, then get on TRT and get jacked.

It was funny hearing you say earlier that you don't necessarily feel classically masculine—you're a masculine dude!

Don't get me wrong, I am crushing a specific type of masculinity, sort of like Eastern European diner owner. You know what I mean? When the mob wife trend was going around the internet, I was like, "I'm built for this."

I do think that fat guy swag is a very powerful force if you can bottle it. And I definitely see myself as in a lineage of these fat guys that I really looked up to, even as a kid. We're talking Farley, John Candy, Jack Black. I don't think anybody would look at me and say,

"That guy's feminine." I don't think I'm getting that. But I guess I'm just trying to say is for people who feel like they're not [masculine], there's a version of [them that] is. You could be a mix of masculine and feminine. If you want to be masculine and you don't feel it, there's a path for you to project that.

How did you come to your own path?

A lot of my body insecurity kind of stemmed from just general insecurity about relationships, and getting attention from girls. But I think for me, it was when I unlocked, "Oh, women actually don't really care that much, if they like you as a person, if you can show what's good about you." When I was confident in myself in all these other ways, when it felt like I'm doing what I need to do, I have a nice life plan, I feel confident in my abilities..." That inner confidence sort of projected. There are times, don't get me wrong, there are times where I'm like, "Jesus, I feel like shit, I look like shit." There are moments of that, but it's just like, "Well, I'm in this body now, so make the best of it."

What do you look for in a partner? What do you want out of a romantic relationship, out of a home life?

I have been thinking about this a lot. I think it's cool to be a provider, whatever, but I'm also very attracted to ambition. I like somebody who's doing their own thing. I like talking to somebody about their long-term goals. I have to think strategically about my career. I like having those long discussions with somebody. As much as I do love stand-up, essentially I'm running my own business.

You've been busy.

I've been overdoing it because once you get a shot in entertainment, you kind of have to take it. But I remember thinking like, "Fuck. I'm so tired. It'd be cool if I got home and the place was clean and maybe there was food. I don't want to order food." I was like, "What if I was dating somebody who'd just be here? It'd be cool if she lived there and

just took care of shit. I'm doing so well. She wouldn't even need a job." I backwards invented the concept of a traditional house.

A sense of humor, for me, really is what my whole life is based around. You actually want a little more pushback from your girlfriend. You want her to be like, "Shut up. You're a fucking idiot."

But you also got to be able to make her laugh.

Got to make her laugh. And you got to make her laugh despite her not wanting to. That's a big one. My favorite audience member is a reluctant girlfriend at the start of the show who becomes a fan by the end of it.

What do you look for in a male friend? What do you want in your boys?

My best friends I've known since I was in kindergarten. My producer on the podcast and my best friend, he's my tour manager. But every five years I tend to pick up another best friend. I know they're a good person, and so then I can make these incredibly fucked up jokes with them. I don't want someone who is racist or somebody who actually doesn't think gay people should get married or thinks it's good to limit the right to choose. We do have to align on the big stuff for me to be able to trust you to then do the funniest jokes in the world, which are really fucked up things.

[I want] that feeling of the basement when you're 14 and you are a loser. It's right before sex enters your mind. There's an innocence to these male friends. Can they be breeding grounds for white power recruitment offices? Maybe. But they can also be truly the most wholesome relationship. Friendship is like you're just 12-year-old idiots playing Game Cube. To me, that is the best part of masculinity. It's just hanging out.

PRODUCTION CREDITS:

Photographs by Chris Maggio

Grooming by Laramie using Augustinus Bader

More From The Great Masculinity Divide

- Jerrod Carmichael Is Still Looking for the [Truth in Masculinity](#)
- Arnold Schwarzenegger: 'I'm What I Would Call a Company Queen'
- Dirtbags Made Comedian Stavros Halkias Famous. [Now He's Helping Them Remake Their Lives.](#)
- Men Say They Want to Be Married. [Terry Real Can Help.](#)
- Why Some of Tech's Leading Men Went All-In on Trump, [According to Chamath Palihapitiya](#)
- [MMA Fighter Khalil Rountree Jr.](#) Wants Men to Accept Their Softer Side
- Pete Buttigieg [Has a Case to Make to American Men](#)
- [Singer 2hollis](#) Grew Up on Minecraft. Now He Hosts Primordial Mosh Pits.

[Jack Crosbie](#) is a writer and editor based in New York. His work has ranged from political correspondence to war reporting, with a particular focus on masculinity and its effects on modern society, from mixed martial arts to domestic extremism. He is a Contributing Writer at *Rolling Stone* as well as ... [Read More](#)

RELATED STORIES FOR GQ

MASCULINITY

Get the GQ Manual

The latest fashion and culture intel, hand-picked for you by GQ editors every day.

SIGN UP

By signing up you agree to our [User Agreement](#) (including the [class action waiver and arbitration provisions](#)), our [Privacy Policy & Cookie Statement](#) and to receive marketing and account-related emails from GQ. You can unsubscribe at any time. This site is protected by reCAPTCHA and the Google [Privacy Policy](#) and [Terms of Service](#) apply.

Read More

Culture

Adam Friedland Could Be the Millennial Jon Stewart. But Does He Want That?

By Kieran Press-Reynolds , Photography by Bobby Doherty

Culture

Hasan Piker Thinks America Might Be Cooked

By Kieran Press-Reynolds , Photography by Molly Matalon

Culture

MMA Fighter Khalil Rountree Jr. Wants Men to Accept Their Softer Side

By Jack Crosbie

Culture

Arnold Schwarzenegger: 'I'm What I Would Call a Company Queen'

By Zach Baron

Culture

Pete Buttigieg Has a Case to Make to American Men

By Jack Crosbie

Culture

Singer 2hollis Grew Up on Minecraft. Now He Hosts Primordial Mosh Pits.

By Eileen Cartter

Wellness

The Real-Life Diet of Lee Pace, Who Loves to Sleep for 12 Hours

By Raymond Ang

Culture

How *Lurker* Director Alex Russell Went From Writing for *The Bear* and *Beef* to Making One of the Summer's Best Movies

By Frazier Tharpe

Wellness

The Real-Life Diet of Jordan Davis, Who Does Smelling Salts in a Solo Cup Before Shows

By Matthew Roberson

Culture

Men Say They Want to Be Married. Terry Real Can Help.

By Katherine Stoeffel

Wellness

The Real Life Diet of Ollie Muhl, Who Used to Eat Panda Express Three Times a Week

By Nick Remsen

Culture

***Peacemaker* Star Frank Grillo on Becoming the DCU's Nick Fury and the 'Big' Secret DC Project That's Coming Next**

By Derek Lawrence

